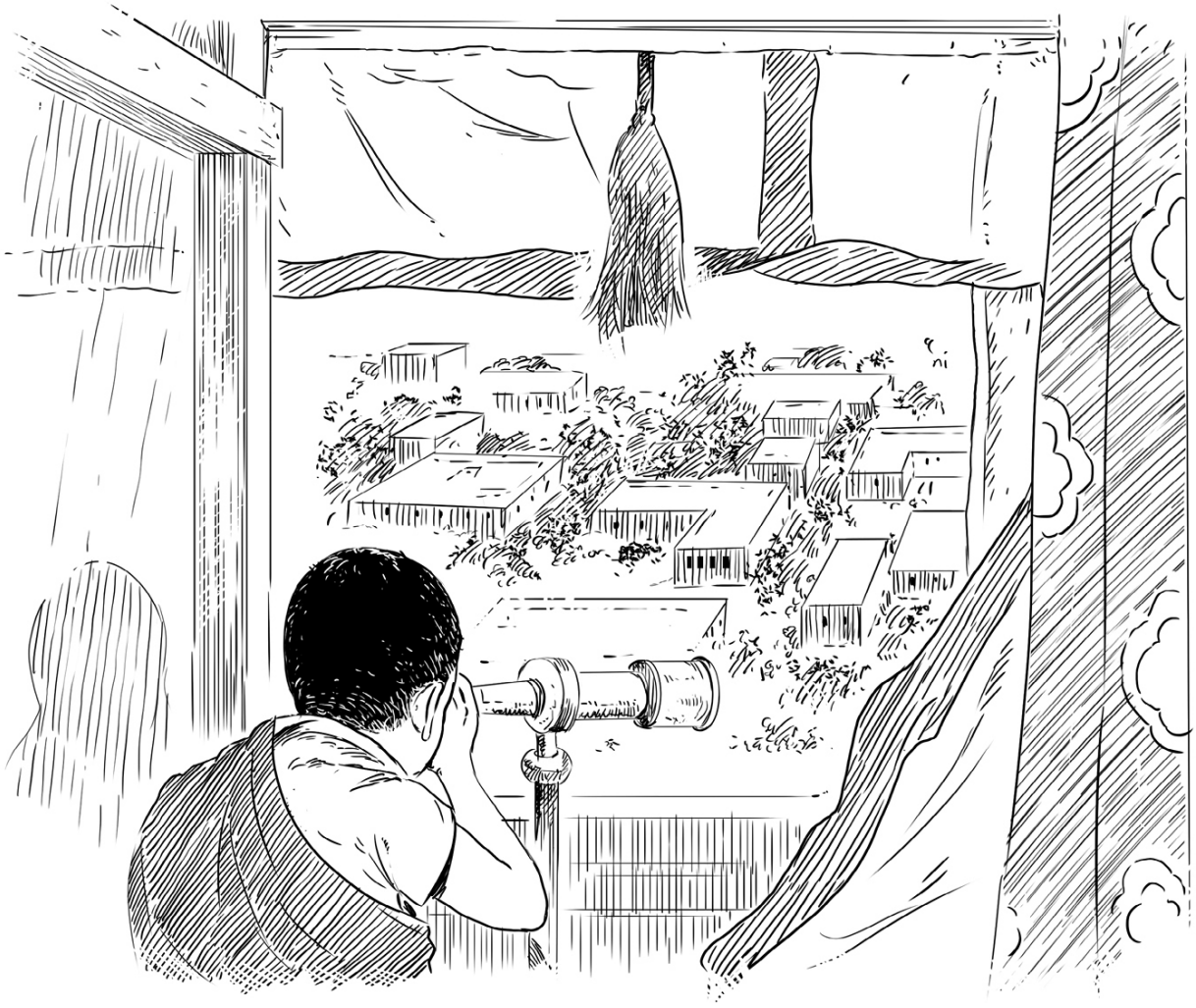


The Dalai Lama’s rooms were high in the palace and often dark and smoky from the oil lamps. He wasn’t allowed to have friends his own age, and he was lonely. He would watch the children in the city below through a telescope and wonder why he couldn’t join them. So he became friends with the palace servants. He was very close to the monk in charge of his meals, a man he called Ponpo. Ponpo was as kind and compassionate as the Dalai Lama’s mother had been. He played with the Dalai Lama and even gave him lumps of sugar as a treat.

The Dalai Lama’s brother Lobsang, who was two years older, was allowed to live with him at the Potala. And the Tibetan government provided a house for his family nearby. The Dalai Lama visited them there. Because Buddhism taught that one should not kill any living thing, the Dalai Lama and the monks at the palace didn’t eat food from animals. But at his parents’ house, the Dalai Lama would sneak fish, eggs, and pork. He